



## BEFORE

The Republican Party chose Union war hero Ulysses S. Grant as its presidential candidate in 1868 because he was popular and a firm supporter of Reconstruction.

## TWO TERMS

In the 1868 election, **Grant won 52.7 percent of the popular vote and 214 votes in the Electoral College** against 80 for his Democratic rival, Horatio Seymour. Despite a deluge of scandals, Grant himself remained popular and won a second term in 1872, when his rival was the veteran *New York Tribune* editor, Horace Greeley (see [War with Mexico](#)), leading an uneasy coalition of breakaway Liberal Republicans and Democrats. This time, **Grant won 55.8 percent of the popular vote** and 286 electoral college votes.

## THE FIFTEENTH AMENDMENT

First proposed in Congress a few weeks before Grant's inauguration, the Fifteenth Amendment (see [Military districts](#)) states: "The **right of citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged** ... on account of race, color, or previous condition of servitude." The ratification process was completed on February 3, 1870.

**D**isillusionment with the Republican Party was a major factor in the failure of Reconstruction. In 1869, General Ulysses S. Grant succeeded Andrew Johnson as president, but during the course of his two terms in the White House, a scandal-racked administration made the word "Grantism" a synonym for political corruption. Grant himself was honest, but he was inexperienced—at age 46 when first inaugurated, he was the youngest U.S. president until that time—and politically inept. Loyalty to old comrades made him appoint men who proved to be all too fallible. In addition, the very nature of the political "spoils system"—by which elected politicians were able to obtain government jobs for party supporters—encouraged dishonesty. Men close to Grant, some of whom were his relatives, were exposed. Cabinet ministers, such as interior secretary Columbus Delano, were found guilty of accepting bribes.